thunderbolts"? On the one hand, "this would be the end of the sacrifices and worship which men offered" the gods and which gods craved. "But, on the other hand, the gods could not suffer [such] insolence to be unrestrained."

If, in the long term, though, we have no alternative, if our choice really is many worlds or none, we are in need of other sorts of myth, myths of encouragement. They exist. Many religions, from Hinduism to Gnostic Christianity to Mormon doctrine, teach that—as impious as it may sound—it is the goal of humans to *become* gods. Or consider a story in the Jewish Talmud left out of the Book of Genesis. (It is in doubtful accord with the account of the apple, the Tree of Knowledge, the Fall, and the expulsion from Eden.) In the Garden, God tells Eve and Adam that He has intentionally left the Universe unfinished. It is the responsibility of humans, over countless generations, to participate with God in a "glorious" experiment—"completing the Creation."

The burden of such a responsibility is heavy, especially on so weak and imperfect a species as ours, one with so unhappy a history. Nothing remotely like "completion" can be attempted without vastly more knowledge than we have today. But perhaps, if our very existence is at stake, we will find ourselves able to rise to this supreme challenge.

ALTHOUGH HE DID NOT quite use any of the arguments of the preceding chapter, it was Robert Goddard's intuition that "the navigation of interplanetary space must be effected to ensure the continuance of the race." Konstantin Tsiolkovsky made a similar judgment:

> There are countless planets, like many island Earths … Man occupies one of them. But why could he not avail himself of others, and of the might of numberless suns?… When the Sun has exhausted its energy, it would be logical to leave it and look for another, newly kindled, star still in its prime.

This might be done earlier, he suggested, long before the Sun dies, "by adventurous souls seeking fresh worlds to conquer."